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pick of the week



Rebel with ragas

Long before musical crossovers became the norm, TR Mahalingam, fondly known as Mali, was rewriting the rules of Carnatic music. The iconic flautist transformed the bamboo flute into a riveting solo instrument with his daring improvisations. Flautist Swaroop Mami pays tribute through signature Mali compositions. *On June 13, from 11am at Kat & Kin Coffee Roasters, Neelankarai. Tickets on bookmyshow.com*



Scene set sounds

Chennai's indie scene is turning up the heat! On June 20, The Summer Bang takes over The Spotted Deer with Hometown Heat — a lively showcase of the city's freshest musical voices. Expect a genre-hopping evening of pop, acoustic, hip hop and alternative sounds with performances by Anjali Manoharan, Stefany Vatz, Sammie, SKA, Shashank Panda and Kavya Subro. Its time to cheer for your local artiste. *On June 20 from 5pm onwards. Tickets on fanpit.in*



Slice dice repeat

Cumin Co. is cutting into new territory with the launch of The Quill, its first-ever precision knife collection. Built around the philosophy of 'from cut to serve,' the range features chef's, santoku and utility knives, alongside a steak knife, sharpening rod and stylish knife block. Crafted from high-carbon stainless steel with ergonomic handles the knives might make chopping, slicing and dicing a little more enjoyable. *Shop on cuminco.com*



Pedal into Madras

Swap the usual Saturday night plans for two wheels and a dose of history at Madras By Night: A Cycle Trail, part of Super Chennai's Summer Festival. Ride through the timeless streets of Triplicane, Chepauk, and Mount Road as the traffic melts away and old Madras reveals its stories. Whether you are a cyclist, history lover, or night owl, this moonlit adventure will bring a fresh way to experience Chennai. *On June 13, 8.30pm onwards. Ticket on kynhood.com*



Karan Gokani

The average person now spends well over two hours a day on social media. Millions of those hours are spent watching complete strangers cooking in their home kitchens. Now logic would suggest these are people looking for inspiration or to learn a new skill, but fascinatingly, most people watching recipes never cook them, or cook at all, for that matter. I know this because I spend a fair amount of my life making recipe videos and interacting with the people who watch them. I have friends who barely venture beyond popping a toast, but tell me they follow my recipe videos religiously. Admitting that they get a sense of joy watching the process alone and never attempt or intend to make the dishes. My wife is no different. We have almost no carpets in our house, yet she can happily spend 20 minutes watching videos of people deep-cleaning carpets. Meanwhile, I can lose a similar amount of time watching somebody in Chennai making dosas despite spending much of my professional life around them. Perhaps we are all just fascinated by people who are very good at something.

Food therapy

Why watching strangers cook has become one of the Internet's most comforting rituals

When people describe why they enjoy food content, the words that come up most often are relaxing and comforting. In a world where so much of the news and social media seems designed to provoke outrage, anxiety, envy and division, there is something reassuring about watching somebody chop an onion, stir a pot or knead a ball of dough. Cooking follows a simple and satisfying narrative. Raw ingredients become something delicious. Hunger is solved. There is a beginning, a middle and an end. It's simple and universally appealing. I also wonder whether these videos satisfy a sense of curiosity and adventure. Travel has become more expensive and

many of us spend more time dreaming about destinations than actually visiting them. Watching somebody cook street food in Bangkok, stretch noodles in Beijing or steam idlis in Bengaluru offers a glimpse into another culture. You may never make or taste the dish yourself, but for a few moments you are transported somewhere else. The hopeful side of me likes to think these videos also play a genuinely educational and unifying role. At least that is certainly my motivation when I write recipes, make videos or work on books. I want to reconnect people with their pasts, give expat Indians a sense of nostalgia, and offer those who have never visited my homeland

PHOTOS: GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK



AT THE TABLE

an introduction to my culture through its food. Hopefully in a way that feels calm, accessible and unthreatening. If that eventually inspires someone to book a ticket and experience the country for themselves, my mission is accomplished. In a fractured world increasingly shaped by misinformation, culture wars and algorithms designed to keep us angry, food remains one of the simplest ways to understand one another. It is difficult to fear a culture once you have sat at its table, shared a meal and realised that the people are often far more alike than the politics would have you believe. All this food porn has had an interesting effect on restaurants too. Diners today are far more informed and adventurous than they were a decade ago. An authenticity check is often only one YouTube video away. People have watched enough grandmothers, street vendors and home cooks online to develop a sense of what feels genuine and what feels manufactured, even if they have never tasted the original dish themselves. Restaurants are challenged to be more honest about what they serve because audiences have become surprisingly good at spotting when something is just a marketing campaign. A more subtle knock-on effect is that even the guests who haven't spent days researching a dish or restaurant doom scrolling social media, are more curious about regional food. They are

willing to travel across a city for a specific dosa, biryani, or a bowl of noodles rather than settling for whatever version happens to be nearby. At its heart, though, I suspect the appeal of watching people cook is much simpler than any of these explanations. Food remains one of the most universal forms of human connection. Long before restaurants, cookbooks, or social media existed, people gathered around fires to prepare meals together. Watching someone cook meant more than learning how dinner was made. It was how stories were passed on, conversations unfolded and people found their place around the table. The technology might have changed dramatically but the instinct remains the same. Today we gather around screens rather than stoves and watch people we will never meet prepare dishes we will probably never cook. Yet I suspect somehow it satisfies the same curiosity and creates the same sense of connection. In an online world that often feels designed to divide us, there is something heartwarming about millions of people quietly spending part of their day watching somebody make dinner.

Karan Gokani is a London-based chef and restaurateur who spends his time cooking, travelling and exploring what the world is eating. He loves the gym, biryani and his frying pan. Not necessarily in that order.

On Secret Sauce's new menu is a slate of salads, pizzas, sandwiches, and beverages, hinging on nostalgia. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The crust strikes back

At Secret Sauce in Alwarpet, travel memories and personal cravings find their way onto crisp, thin-crust pizzas and house hot sauces. We start with a spicy Siesta

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If you've eaten a thin-crust pizza in Chennai any time in the last decade, chances are that you have heard of Ox and Tomato and wondered what happened to it. The answer is not a comeback. It is Secret Sauce, a new venture from Sandesh Reddy, soft-launching this weekend before opening fully on Monday in Alwarpet, in the space that used to house Finale Dessert Bar. Mansi, who ran Ox and Tomato for years and is Sandesh's partner both in business and marriage, did consider reviving that nostalgia for years. "Ox and Tomato saw people who'd walk in everyday to split a meal or just grab and go. People in the neighbourhood had

their own favourite items on the menu," she says. The two, who have worked together on a menu for the first time, say that it became clear that recreating something from a different era, in a market with so much choice now, was not the best approach. "Trying to recreate an Ox and Tomato in today's market, when there's so much option and choices, I didn't think it was the smartest decision, product-wise. The two of us have come together to work on a menu for the first time," Sandesh says, laughing. Today, they are looking to point the nostalgia in a different direction. At Secret Sauce, the menu is built on travel memories and personal cravings, translated onto a 12-inch pizza, Sandesh says. The Siesta with a spicy Goan chorizo pork sausage, pineapple,

jalapeno on a curry base, for instance, comes from times that Sandy has spent trying shack-style meals by the Arabian Sea. He says that it has the exact lazy, sun-soaked quality. On the menu, this is a clear winner. The pepperoni and the chilli-cheese-toast-inspired pizza (reportedly the only dish Sandesh and Mansi agree on) are equally solid — no surprises, just good pizza done right. "A lot more pepperoni," he tells Chef Perumal who has been working with him for 15 years. Not every experiment lands the same for every palate. The Thai-inspired pizza with prawns, built around a green curry base, came through with a fairly generous hand of basil and lemongrass, making for a more herb-forward bite than expected. What ties the pizzas together is the crust — thin, crisp, and

noticeably lighter than what Chennai is used to today. The dough is cold-fermented for 48 hours but kept low on yeast, then spends about six minutes in a custom Australian oven with ceramic heaters at 400-450°C, giving it a dry, brittle bite. A Neapolitan-style crust, he says, would drown out flavours like the Thai curry or chilli cheese. The price range for these pizzas sits between ₹450 and ₹650, and Sandesh is upfront that this is meant to be an everyday spot, not an occasion-only indulgence. There's also a fun side story. Secret Sauce has teamed up with Maadi Mart, an interesting Chennai-based brand that makes its own range of condiments and a phenomenal curry leaf zaatar potato chip, on a trio of house hot sauces. At Secret Sauce, the Siesta (and one that follows after), alone is worth the trip. Secret Sauce is at 10, CV Raman Road, Natesan Colony, Alwarpet. A meal for two costs around ₹800.

Something special

Sumukhi Suresh on taking the stage at Netflix Is A Joke Fest 2026, and staying uncomfortable and honest

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I am from India of course, but I'm also specifically from South India," Sumukhi Suresh declares, onstage in Los Angeles. As a part of the global comedy festival Netflix Is A Joke Fest 2026 in May, Sumukhi was the only female Indian comic to feature in the lineup. A few weeks later, when we catch up with her, the comic is still basking in the glow of her Los Angeles adventure. "I was given a slot at 9.45 pm to perform, which made me very nervous since LA seemed sleepy and quiet at that time. I however, got to perform to a full house and asked them to warn me if they were feeling sleepy. It felt like I was performing for people who had specially come to watch me; so it was less of a performance and more of a conversation with incredible energy," she says. The comedy fest, which had a host of different live events including stand-up comedy shows, brought together over 130 people in comedy from across the world. Some comics who took the stage included Ali Wong, Shane Gillis, Nikki Glaser, Matt Rife, Nate Bargatze, Sarah Silverman, and John Mulaney, and the festival also had Dave Chapelle, Conan O'Brian and Bill Bur as part of its line-up. Having spent many years in Bengaluru, the comic, who is Tamil, is now based out of Mumbai and juggles stand-up, writing for film and comedy specials, as well as acting. Her last special, Hoemonal, which debuted onstage in 2024, toured across the country as well as at the Edinburgh Fringe. Sumukhi has dealt with a spectrum of themes onstage; if she opened her show in LA with a quip

about how not to assume everyone from India is from the North, her shows in the past have featured everything from dealing with singlehood, body image, health, resilience, and more. "I wouldn't say that this has become easy, but I have got a lot more comfortable with comedy. I have realised that when something makes me uncomfortable onstage, then it is hitting the right note. It should seem like a confession you do not want to make because you know the minute it is out there, all your friends are going to judge you," she laughs. Sumukhi's foray into screenwriting has followed an interesting trajectory. Best known as the creator and writer of the web series Pushpavalli (2017-2020), she more recently wrote dialogues for the 2024 film Ctrl, Vikramaditya Motwane's thriller starring Ananya Panday. "When Mr Motwane first mentioned Ctrl, I remember wondering if I was the right person for it," she recalls. "I thought I was an out-and-out comedy writer until then. I am once again working on something with him which is very different from anything I have done before, and I love writing dialogues for him," she says. Currently working on her next special, Sumukhi says that the performance aspect of stand-up is what she finds the most exciting. "I do not write first. At present, I am performing the hell out of whatever thoughts I have, and then I take a call on putting it all together. I record and listen to myself again and again. What Hoemonal taught me was to be patient with a stand up show. This isn't something that is going to come together quickly, and I am ready to wait," she adds.



CONTINUED FROM
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Western media often caricatured them as travelling in tightly organised groups, cameras slung around their necks, photographing everything in sight and rushing from one landmark to the next. The stereotype became so pervasive that psychiatrists even coined the term Paris Syndrome to describe the profound disappointment some Japanese visitors reportedly experienced when the romanticised Paris of their imagination failed to match reality.

“We are not the exception. We are the latest occupant of a chair the Japanese sat in, then the Chinese, and someone else will inherit the moment a new economy puts a few hundred million first-time passport-holders on planes.”

What makes the Indian traveller particularly vulnerable to stereotyping, he argues, is visibility.

“For most of the world, the Indian in front of them is the only India they will ever get,” he says. “The German behaving badly by the pool gets read as an individual. We get read as a category.”

The spotlight on Indians

Journalist Prathap Nair, who grew up across South India and has spent the better part of a decade living in Germany, suspects the obsession with the supposedly unruly Indian traveller is often stronger in India than abroad.

“One viral video does not an unruly Indian traveller make,” he says. “Just because you’ve seen a couple of videos of people singing bhajans, shouting religious slogans or behaving badly abroad doesn’t mean that’s representative of millions of Indians who travel every year.”

Whenever he encounters Indian travellers in Europe, Prathap says, they are largely polite, respectful and eager to follow the rules.



(Representative images) Indian travellers have increasingly found themselves at the centre of controversy, both at home and abroad. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



Extra baggage

“Most people are trying to blend in, not stand out.” What social media captures, he argues, is not everyday behaviour but exceptional behaviour.

“The problem is that social media rewards the unusual. Nobody posts a video of tourists following the rules and minding their own business. They post the one incident that gets clicks,” says Prathap.

An IT consultant from Bengaluru, who requested anonymity because of the sensitive nature of his comments, believes the conversation around Indian travellers cannot be separated from questions of class, hierarchy and how people relate to places they perceive as being “for them”.

In his experience, some of the behaviour criticised abroad is not unique to international travel at all. Similar patterns

can often be observed within India itself. “You see it when tourists from big cities travel to places such as Ladakh, the Northeast, Mussoorie or Shimla,” he says. “The locals want tourism and depend on it economically, so they tolerate a lot. But that doesn’t mean they aren’t frustrated.”

He recalls conversations with hospitality professionals in the hills who spoke about the need to constantly remind visitors, especially from the North, to be mindful of their surroundings.

“I remember a hotelier in Mussoorie telling me that they routinely have to request guests from metropolitan cities to lower the volume of their music because people forget they’re in a quiet mountain town and not in the middle of a city,” he says.

For him, the issue is often rooted in social conditioning.



“India is a deeply hierarchical society. Class, status and power shape many of our interactions, often without us even realising it. Sometimes those assumptions travel with us.”

In his experience, Indians often behave differently depending on where they are travelling. “I’ve noticed that people are generally more

India now accounts for more than 30 million international departures annually, while Indian travellers spend upwards of US\$40 billion (around ₹3,798 crore) overseas every year

conscious of rules and social norms in Europe or the United States,” he says. “But in parts of Southeast Asia, where travel is cheaper and more accessible, you occasionally see a greater sense of entitlement.”

“That’s not true of every traveller, obviously,” he says. “But there can be an unconscious tendency to be more deferential in places we perceive as powerful and less mindful in places we don’t,” he says.

Gcobani Mancotywa, regional general manager (Australasia, MEISEA and China) at South African Tourism, notes that India is among South Africa’s top 10 source markets globally. Nearly

70,000 Indians visited South Africa in 2025, while more than 82,500 travelled there between January 2025 and March 2026. More importantly, he says, Indian travellers are increasingly seeking authentic and immersive experiences centred around wildlife, culture, food and local communities.

“Indian travellers are valued not only for the economic contribution they make across the tourism value chain, but also for the meaningful way in which they engage with the destination,” Gcobani says.

If social media sees Indian travellers through the lens of viral videos, the travel industry sees them through the lens of numbers.

Keyur Joshi, founder of eco-resort Tipai by Wildlife Luxuries, located around 170 kilometres from Nagpur, and formerly part of MakeMyTrip, touted as India’s largest online travel company, argues that the conversation online bears little resemblance to how destinations, airlines and hospitality brands view the Indian traveller.

“Social media amplifies isolated incidents, while the travel industry looks at growth, spending and long-term value,” he says.

According to estimates cited by Keyur, India now accounts for more than 30 million international departures

annually, while Indian travellers spend upwards of US\$40 billion (around ₹3,798 crore) overseas every year. Increasingly, that money is being spent on luxury accommodation, curated experiences, gastronomy, wellness and adventure travel.

“Indian outbound travel has evolved from a volume story to a value story,” Keyur says. “The industry isn’t focussed on a viral reel from an airport. It’s looking at a traveller who is spending more, travelling further and becoming increasingly important to destinations worldwide.”

That does not mean all criticism is unwarranted. Rahul Jagtiani, luxury travel specialist and host of travel podcast, The Plush Podcast, believes India is producing a new generation of international travellers at extraordinary speed.

“When millions of people from a rapidly rising economy begin travelling the world, they become impossible to ignore. And once that happens, every mildly ridiculous holiday moment begins carrying a weight it was never meant to bear,” says Rahul.

That may be the real burden of being an Indian traveller today. Not that people notice when you get something wrong, but that they often assume you were speaking for everyone else when you did.

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Tejaswi Subramanian

While growing up in Coimbatore, womanhood often felt like a set of carefully drawn borders. My college taught about gender, work and the economy, but the subtler lessons were about containment: do not draw attention, do not step out, and do not take up public space. It is a tension many women in South India carry. As Bengaluru-based sex and trauma therapist Neha Bhat puts it, “It’s the same cognitive dissonance: you asked me to put myself first, but are you supporting me systemically to do that?” She adds, “There is always a kind of dissonance in the body when that happens.”

Within this landscape, kink is emerging as a revelation. “Especially for women, shadow experiences are part of desire,” says Neha, referring to fantasies, curiosities or parts of oneself that may be suppressed or deemed socially unacceptable. “Women are leading the conversation right now. Power has shifted from a male-driven narrative to a femme-driven one.” What appears taboo, she suggests, often signals a move away from performance towards agency.

Shimmer’s entry into kink was not born from transgression but with a sensation she could not name during a rope session, often known as Japanese shibari or kinbaku – a practice that uses rope to create patterns of restraint and sensation, with an emphasis on trust and communication between partners.

“The memories of handcuffs and a blindfold came flooding in from decades ago,” says the Chennai native, who is in her mid-40s and self-employed.

For her, shibari became a way for the body to speak before the mind explained itself. “I realised I may want to explore with women,” she says. Not as identity upheaval, but as curiosity.

Chennai-based Bee, who is in her mid-30s and an artist-designer, first encountered shibari in Puducherry last year at a residential retreat led by Bengaluru-based practitioner Amiya Bhanushali, who hosts intimate, multi-day kink and rope retreats once or twice a year across different locations under her studio, Silly Hands Shibari, touted as India’s only rope-dedicated studio.



Knot tied down

How consent-led spaces are helping women explore intimacy, boundaries and agency beyond traditional ideas of relationships

Among them was a recent femme-only retreat in Rishikesh called The Great Baddie Pilgrimage, held in November last year.

The Rishikesh retreat was designed exclusively for women and FLINTA (female, lesbian, intersex, non-binary, trans and agender) individuals. With much of her social media audience being men, Amiya wanted to create a space where bodies and curiosity did not have to negotiate the male gaze.

Bee had also been particular about learning from a woman, especially in a rope culture that often leans male. “I was tired of the

male dom/femme sub aesthetic,” she says. For her, a woman-led space allowed her to explore sensuality without expectation.

Opening up Amiya describes her work as “container-building”.

“Only when you trust the space and facilitators are you open to vulnerability,” she says. “At the workshop, we began with trust falls – a simple exercise where one person leans back and relies on another to catch them.”

In practice, rope work begins with participants being taught basic knots



Beyond the assumptions, kink communities are framing the practice around trust, consent, and the creation of emotionally safe places.
INSTAGRAM/SILLY HANDS SHIBARI



and ways of handling rope safely, before moving into patterns that wrap around the body – sometimes creating sleeves or harnesses that hold the arms or torso in place. As trust builds, the exercises may involve light restraint that limits movement. More advanced techniques, such as partial or full suspension, are typically demonstrated by the facilitators

rather than practised by beginners.

What stayed with Bee after the workshop was not just the technique, but the atmosphere. “I became comfortable tying others and being tied, simply as a sensual, playful practice.”

The number of participants varies depending on the retreat. A recent retreat in Rishikesh was limited to 12 spots and cost approximately ₹26,000 on the early-bird rate. The fee included accommodation for three nights and four days, as well as activities like massage sessions, sound healing and a pottery workshop. Typically, the organisers cap



Women are leading the conversation right now. Power has shifted from a male-driven narrative to a femme-driven one

NEHA BHAT
Sex and trauma therapist

attendance at around 10 participants. In addition to the residential retreats, they regularly conduct non-residential, single-day rope workshops priced between ₹1,000 and ₹2,000 per person at the studio in Bengaluru, in Mumbai, Puducherry and other cities. They also offer private rope-tying sessions in clients’ homes, which cost approximately ₹4,000 to ₹5,000 per session.

They have been hosting roughly one retreat annually for the past few years.

Come undone For many women, kink is not about breaking rules but about finally hearing themselves. Simran Sanganageria, a sexuality educator who attended the Rishikesh retreat, describes it as a return to the body.

Many at the retreat describe unlearning familiar scripts, where men are expected to make the first move and women to receive, or where intimacy is narrowly defined by traditional gender roles. Participants explore other ways of connecting, where power can be exchanged, paused or shared, rather than assumed.

This unfolding exists within a larger contradiction. While South Indian states rank as relatively safe for women, lived experience still teaches vigilance. Within that tension, kink offers a space where boundaries are spoken, power is negotiated and the body is handled with care.

For Shimmer, those shifts did not remain inside the retreat. They followed her home. “If I have specific wants, I now voice it more clearly,” she says. “If I don’t want to receive more, I will say it.”

She describes approaching intimacy with more intention. Whether imagining a threesome or navigating a one-on-one encounter, she says she now thinks through “the entire flow” – what each person is comfortable with, how the experience unfolds and what care looks like afterwards.

For others, the translation is more subtle. Bee, who has not actively sought out a kink community since, describes carrying the experience more as a memory than a routine.

Chennai, as Bee notes, does not yet have a visible and safe kink community. So what these spaces offer is not just experimentation, but a place to practise communication, consent and curiosity.



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Harikrishnan Keezhathil Surendran Pillai, or Harri KS, is no stranger to latex. Long before the Kerala-born designer founded his label Harri, following his graduation from the London College of Fashion’s Master of Arts Fashion Design Technology (Menswear) programme in 2020, he was helping his father, Surendran Pillai, on their small (under one acre) plantation in Kollam.

The process was direct. “In Kerala, latex production is part of everyday life,” he says. “You tap the tree in the morning, collect the latex, begin forming sheets by afternoon, and then dry and cure them over time to create the final raw material.” He is quick to clarify the distinction: what his father produces is raw, agricultural latex, largely destined for industrial use. “I use fashion-grade latex for my clothes.” Harri’s work is known for its sculptural, inflated latex garments, particularly the now-recognisable balloon trousers. Harri did not set out to become a designer. If anything, he was trying to break free from the expectations society placed on him to become



either a doctor or an engineer. His early ambition was simply to leave home after finishing school at St Jude’s in Kollam. Admission to the National Institute of Fashion Technology in Bangalore in 2012 became, as he puts it, “that exit.”

Before fashion, however, there was bodybuilding, which he pursued seriously in the years leading up to that move. It is here that the foundations of his design language were laid. “When you’re in that world, you start to really understand and appreciate form, because bodybuilding is entirely about that,” he says.

What endured was the philosophy behind bodybuilding. “It’s about constantly chasing a version of yourself that feels impossible. You’re never really satisfied,” says Harri. Fashion, he realised, followed a similar rhythm. Each collection feels definitive until it isn’t. “When I finished my graduate collection, I thought, ‘This is it.’ But then, a couple of years later, there was something new,” Harri remembers.

That graduate collection, Let’s Put Him in a Vase, marked a turning point. Developed at the London College of Fashion, it arrived without much expectation from those around him. “A lot of people I



Shape shifter

Raised around rubber plantations in Kerala, designer Harri KS is rethinking latex, form, and the idea of wearability

was studying with were quite surprised it became what it did,” he says.

That early recognition translated into more formal support. Harri became part of the British Fashion Council’s NEWGEN programme, which provides funding, mentorship, and a platform within London Fashion Week

Since his debut on the London schedule in 2023, he has shown six runway collections, the latest being his Spring/Summer 2026 outing, MuseumWear. The pieces in the collection move across familiar categories – bomber jackets, long coats, denim sets, tailored trousers, knitwear – but they’re all slightly unsettled, as if he has not quite let them sit comfortably in their usual roles. “Latex isn’t just tied to the usual associations of fetish or excess; it’s a material that shapes the body in a precise, almost

architectural way,” he says, adding, “it (latex) is quite a demanding material. It doesn’t behave like fabric – you can’t drape it in the same way or rely on it to fall naturally. You’re working with sheets, bonding them together, shaping them gradually. The gloss people associate with latex isn’t inherent, you actually have to polish it, so there’s a whole finishing process that becomes part of the garment,” says Harri. Moments like



Sam Smith wearing his work to the Brit Awards 2023 gave the label early momentum. He speaks about these moments without romanticising them. “It’s a major push, as it gives momentum and validates your practice,” he says, describing it as an investment rather than an endpoint.

On the global stage

In 2025, he presented his largest inflatable piece to date at the Victoria and Albert Museum’s Late Friday event, and was included in the Design Museum’s 30 Years of London Fashion exhibition. He has also worked across music and television, designing costumes for Katy Perry’s Lifetimes tour, and contributing to Björk’s Fossora visuals. There is a desire for the brand to grow, to sell, and to move beyond the runway, even as he



(From far left) Sam Smith in Harri; looks from MuseumWear; and, Tilda Swinton in custom Harri; (below) Harri KS.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

maintains a certain distance from fashion culture itself. “I don’t have any connection with the fashion culture,” he says, tracing that back to Kerala, where clothing carried little social weight. “What matters is how good you are at what you do,” says Harri.

Today, the label is stocked selectively across international markets, including H. Lorenzo in Paris and retailers in South Korea, extending its reach beyond the London system.

After graduating, he moved to Delhi, where he worked briefly with fashion designer Suket Dhir, an experience that introduced him to the mechanics of the industry. Today, his work spans multiple geographies. Latex is largely sourced from Malaysia, while denim development happens across Ahmedabad, Chennai, Bengaluru, and Mumbai.

He returns to Kerala once or twice a year, though not for inspiration: “When I’m there, I step into the role of a son – I’m not a designer.”

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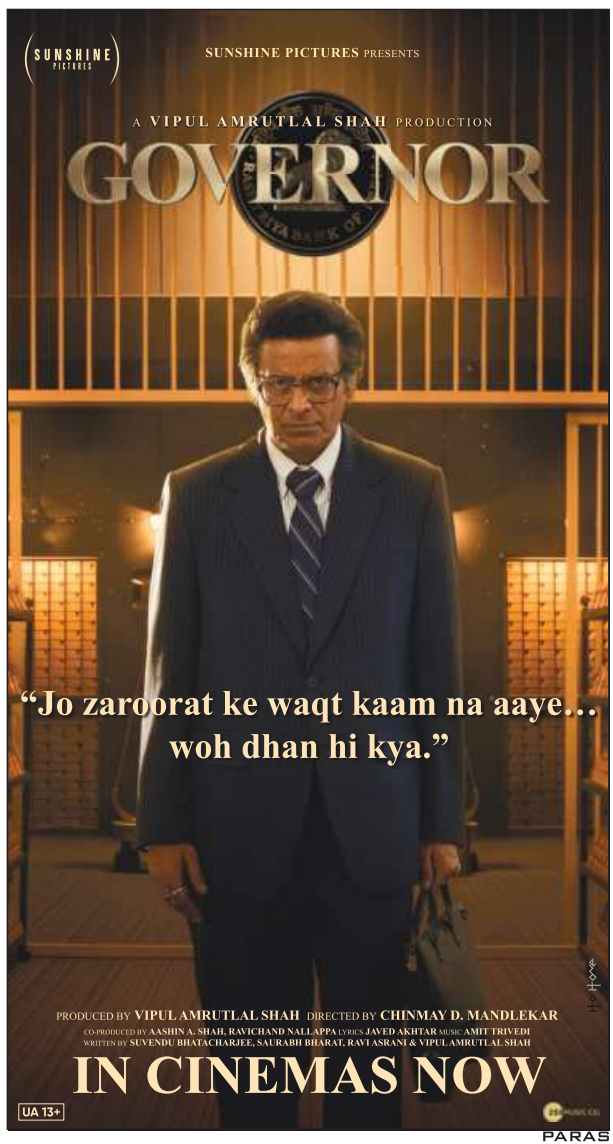
As World Cup fever sweeps Kerala, designers are creating customised lungis and unisex wraps featuring star players

He offers T-shirt-mundu combos as well. The highest demand, however, is



Whether Messi or Ronaldo, fans can now literally wear their passion for football – on their mundus!

(Clockwise from left)
Lungis at Puthuma Collections; Ochuma's football edit; Bolo's Neymar mundu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Malayalam

A flawed, bloated exposé



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A minor act of revolt can be your undoing in the film industry, where power centres are not very tolerant of those who do not fall in line. Vineeth Madhavan (Naslen), the filmmaker protagonist of *Mollywood Times*, goes the whole hog in his attempt to make his first film without any compromises. In the process, we see his worldview transform from optimistic to cynical.

Scene after scene seethes with the anger and frustration of someone who experiences his dream slipping away from grasp for no fault of his, so much so that one begins to wonder how much of the events in the film have been drawn from the life of its filmmaker, Abhinav Sunder Nayak.

In this world filled with fake smiles, selfish interests and ulterior motives, Vineeth is almost a lonely warrior for his vision, with his passion for the art almost consuming him. Sometimes, Vineeth radiates a mild superiority complex, especially in how the other successful filmmakers are even made to gloat to him of their success despite their mediocrity.

Although the struggles of an aspiring filmmaker in a cutthroat industry make one want to root for Vineeth, he also carries the vibes of Howard Roark, the problematic protagonist of Ayn Rand's *The Fountainhead*, in his uncompromising and obsessive nature. Filmmaking, in his worldview, is an individualistic pursuit, with Vineeth having lines that downplay the efforts of every other crew member other than the writer-director.

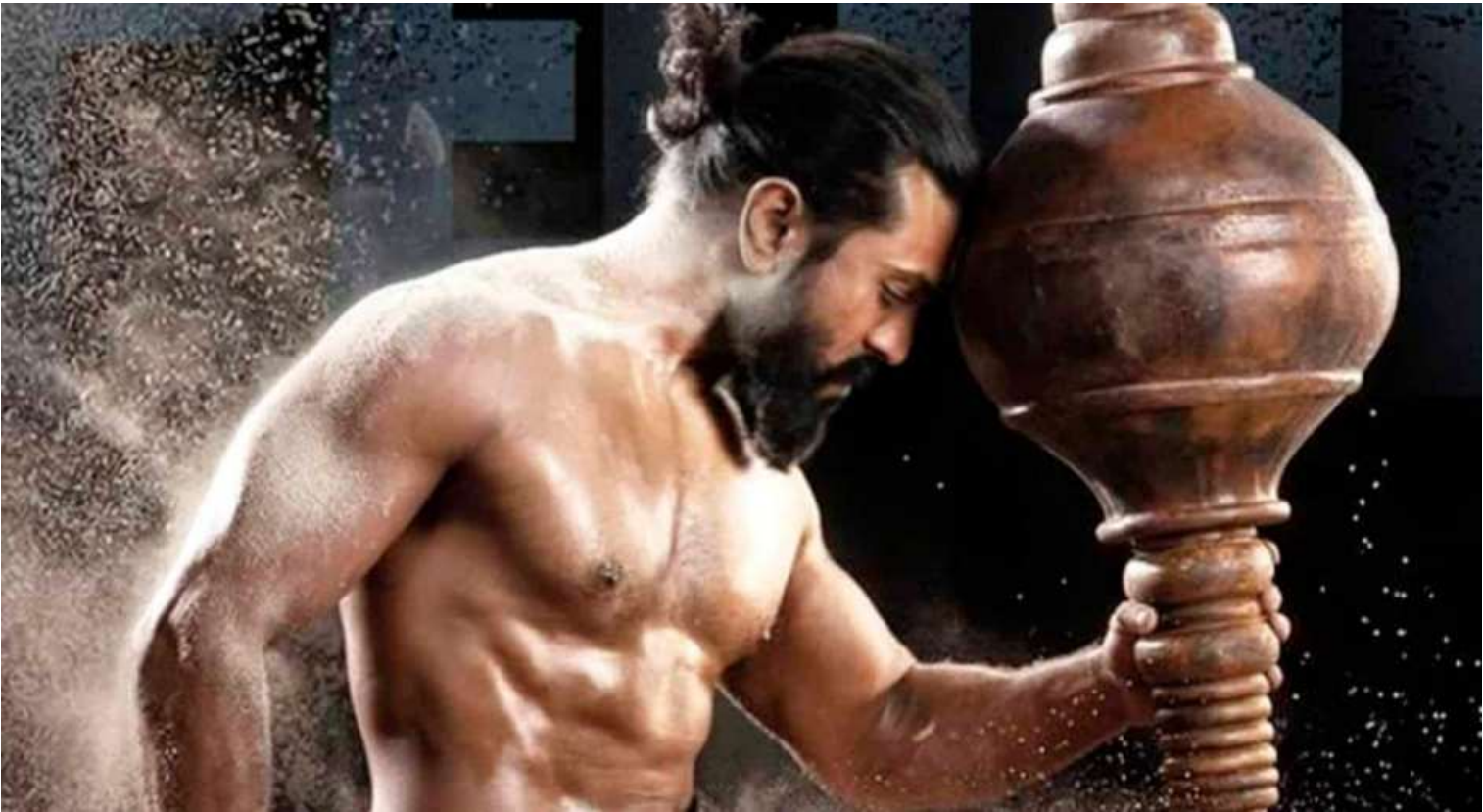
Some of the other ideas also do not sit well with the film's theme, especially the protagonist's claim that some filmmakers are celebrated despite their mediocre work only because they belong to underprivileged backgrounds – an unfortunate claim to make, especially when only few from such backgrounds make it in cinema.

These missteps almost take the sheen away from the genuinely nice touches in the film – from the protagonist's childhood fascination with cinema, to the many depictions of the ills in the industry. The fictionalisation of insider stories will have quite a few people nodding in approval while leaving a few squirming in their seats.

The editing in quite a few scenes was top-notch, but the filmmaker also being one of the editors means that not much trimming seems to have been done. This is most felt in the latter half, when things get tiresome and repetitive. A much leaner film with better writing in the final act could have left a more defining impact.

Marketed as a "hate letter to cinema", *Mollywood Times* would have worked better as an exposé of the dark underbelly of the film industry if not for the stretched phases that make it a bloated work.

Mollywood Times is currently running in theatres



A weakly-written sports drama

Despite its overstuffed screenplay, *Peddi* finds strength in Ram Charan's commanding turn, AR Rahman's stirring score and Ratnavelu's evocative imagery

Telugu

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Pudathama enti malli? (Will we be born again?), Ram Charan's character Peddi asks at several points in his new Telugu film directed by Buchi Babu Sana. More statement than question, the line underscores the protagonist's belief that life comes only once, and his determination to stop at nothing to achieve his goal. Buchi Babu frames Peddi's fight for his own identity and that of his village like a sports biopic, powered by Ram Charan's performance, A.R. Rahman's music and R. Ratnavelu's evocative visuals.

The 189-minute film travels back to the 1990s. When a member of the Indian Olympics Association, played by Boman Irani, witnesses an extraordinary spectacle in and around Vizianagaram, Andhra Pradesh, he is drawn into Peddi's story. At its core, the film is centred on the struggles of sugarcane field labourers in the region. Yet, its storytelling borrows liberally from sports dramas across languages, evoking everything from *Sarpatta Parambarai* to *Chandu Champion* and *Bhaag Milkha Bhaag*.

Peddi begins as a coolie who channels his prodigious batting talent into local cricket matches, largely for money. Every towering six, often sailing beyond neighbouring grounds, fuels both the crowd's frenzy and his own momentum. Ram Charan convincingly inhabits the rustic, combustible energy of a man for whom cricket is far from a gentleman's game. Here, predators wait to injure batsmen, and a labourer must win not just matches but also respect from those who wield power over him.

The two cricket matches, one played during the day and the other at night, gradually help to unmask the region's deep-rooted social inequities. The story brings into focus the plight of Peddi's village, a nameless settlement with no

Peddi

Director: Buchi Babu Sana

Cast: Ram Charan, Janhvi Kapoor, Shiva Rajkumar, Jagapathi Babu

Storyline: Sports is the only hope for identity for a daily wager in a remote hamlet. Can he win for himself and his people?



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road or rail connectivity, whose residents have no voting rights and are left to fend for themselves in life and death.

Buchi Babu Sana, who has written the story, along with screenplay writers Nagendra Kasi, Vara Prasad Toleti, Krushna Hari, Venkata Prasad Gandhi and Sri Raman Ch, unfolds this reality through visuals of daily wage workers trekking through forests, interspersed with references to the absence of healthcare and educational facilities. A village elder, Appala Suri (Jagapathi Babu), relentlessly campaigns to get trains to halt at the village, but his efforts prove futile.

Yet, much of this material does not land strongly enough to make us invest in the village's fate. Had these portions been written and executed with greater emotional depth, Peddi's struggle for identity would have resonated far more powerfully.

Despite Jagapathi Babu's earnest performance, Appala Suri's arc remains emotionally distant, largely because the film falls back on familiar tropes that mainstream cinema has long used to depict rural hardship. While several supporting actors look convincing in their parts, a sense of déjà vu lingers throughout.

A romance track involving Janhvi Kapoor as a local politician's daughter further impedes the narrative. Remove her portions and little would change. The overt sexualisation of the character, coupled with some of the dialogues and situations, feels crass. It's 2026, and Telugu cinema can do better.

The sports sequences, thankfully, bring the film back on track. Ratnavelu and his team establish a convincing vintage visual aesthetic for the rustic sports drama, while Ram Charan excels as the carefree cricketer who later transforms into a wrestler driven by purpose. The wrestling portions may briefly evoke memories of *Dangal* or *Sarpatta Parambarai*, but thanks to Ram Charan and Shiva Rajkumar, the comparison does not linger.

This transformative phase also benefits immensely from A.R. Rahman's score, which shifts seamlessly from the rousing energy of the cricket matches to more

emotionally resonant territory as the narrative evolves. Even when the envy, politics and power struggles of the sporting arena feel familiar, Ram Charan and Rahman make the uneven stretches watchable.

The film also assembles actors from different industries in a bid to appeal to a pan-Indian audience. However, barring Shiva Rajkumar, few are given enough material to make an impression, their roles often bordering on caricature. The inconsistent lip-sync further distracts.

In the latter portions, the visual effects used to recreate the village and railway tracks dilute the story's realism. In contrast, the Delhi sequences, shot on film cameras, stand out for their rich and authentic texture.

Towards the end, a major plot twist functions more as a shock tactic than the culmination of a well-earned character arc. Once again, the problem lies in the writing. For viewers familiar with mainstream cinema, the reveal is also easy to anticipate. Buchi Babu Sana employed a similar device in his debut film *Uppena*, but there it felt organic to the emotional rhythms of the story.

It is also difficult not to think of Sukumar's *Rangasthalam*, starring Ram Charan, for which Buchi Babu Sana was part of the writing team. That film established its social hierarchies with far greater clarity, making the audience deeply invested in the protagonist's journey and rebellion. Here, we hear a lot about inequality but rarely feel its weight.

And yet, if the film's final sporting moments still manage to move us, much of the credit belongs to A.R. Rahman and Ram Charan. After *Rangasthalam* and *RRR*, this is another defining performance from the actor. Charan fully internalises Peddi's journey and makes every sporting triumph feel earned.

If only *Peddi* had matched its ambition with sharper writing, it might have been truly memorable. Instead, it remains a messy, uneven drama held together by a committed lead performance and a stirring musical score.

Peddi is currently running in theatres

A frantic, polished ride that is entirely aware of its own punchline

Hindi

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By taking India's most exhausted street insult and turning it into a literal roll call – Maa (Madhuri Dixit) and Behen (Triptii Dimri and Dharna Durga) – the prolific Suresh Triveni essentially asks: What if the women routinely weaponised in local cuss words actually team up to hide a dead body or the rot of patriarchal entitlement.

Set in a middle-class housing society, cleverly called Adarsh Colony, *Maa Behen* gradually becomes a physical representation of societal surveillance. The neighbour network, led by Charitra Kumar Gupta (Ravi Kishan), is designed to show how a judgmental community assassinates the character of a single woman, a single mother.

Triveni teams up with writer Pooja Tolani to systematically strip



away the idea of a sacred mother, transforming her into a flawed mastermind in a crime. Rejecting decades of representation that demanded maternal self-sacrifice, the duo replaces it with the raw instinct of self-preservation.

Playing on the characters of a popular detergent jingle, Pooja stitches a sharp social commentary

on the death of traditional shame. The very same middle-class women who were once celebrated for cleaning up domestic mess here use their cleaning skills to outsmart the nosy neighbour.

In this battle, Rekha's (Madhuri) sleeveless blouse becomes a sign of non-compliance. Jaya (Triptii) stands for sensible, well-mannered

protectors of domestic conformity before the fuse bursts, and Sushma (Dharna) is a symbol of the detached, screen addicted, internet generation looking for likes.

Structured as in-your-face subversion, the film relies on the value of watching Madhuri and Triptii handle an unglamorous crisis in a suburban setup. It looks a bit put-on, but that artificiality is exactly what drives the film's campy, satirical tone, explained at every step by Shrivardhan Trivedi of *Sansani* fame.

Unlike *Tumhari Sulu*, Trivedi struggles when he tries to do three things at once: deliver a sharp critique of the idealised Indian mother while also creating the quiet dread of a mystery and loud, rip-roaring comedic moments. The structural tug-of-war doesn't just subvert tropes; it points out that it is doing so. This self-awareness disrupts the story's reality.

Part of the problem is the tonal mismatch between performances. Full marks for taking the plunge in a challenging role, but Madhuri's aura never quite dissolves into the gritty, small-town reality the film needs,

leaving her performance looking like a calculated acting exercise. While she and Triptii operate in a mainstream sitcom register with frequent rolling of eyes, exaggerated gasps, and synchronised shouting, Shardul Bhardwaj and Geetanjali Kulkarni perform with a grounded, textured realism, not acknowledging

Maa Behen

Director: Suresh Triveni

Cast: Madhuri Dixit, Triptii Dimri, Dharna Durga, Ravi Kishan, Geetanjali Kulkarni, Shardul Bhardwaj, Arunoday Singh

Storyline: A fiercely non-conforming widow discovers her nosy neighbour dead inside her kitchen, dragging her estranged daughters into a not-so-accidental crime

that they are in a comedy. Ravi Kishan, who excels in this space, is reduced to a prop. What could have been a fully fleshed-out jugalbandi between him and Madhuri is traded away for a standard trope.

The social commentary about how society polices women loses its impact because the society on screen feels like a sitcom set rather than a real community. As the layout feels engineered for camera angles, the natural tension dissipates. Triveni tries to generate frantic energy to mask the lack of genuine narrative progression, but it doesn't hold. The solution to weak pacing isn't to have the characters talk faster and shout louder.

In the final act, when Madhuri's dramatic gravity takes over, she instantly elevates the material to a poignant study of maternal survival. But it can't rescue the dark comedy, because the makers keep nudging the audience, saying, "Look how edgy we are being!"

Maa Behen is currently streaming on Netflix

